Mile Marker #5: Understanding My Money

The point is to know yourself a little better when it comes to money. Nobody needs a perfect budget.

Leave this module with one honest insight and one realistic intention. There are no right or wrong financial situations here, only honest and not-so-honest responses.

You never have to share your tracker or budget. If you want to attach one, that's your choice.

Two ways to use this handout. It matches the Mile Marker #5 assignment in Blackboard. Print it and fill it in by hand, or type in the boxes below and save a PDF. Either way, upload the photo, scan, or PDF to the assignment. You can also type your answers in Blackboard instead.

NAME _____ **DATE** _____

QUESTION 1

What You Noticed

After completing the Dollar Tracker, what did you learn about your spending patterns? What surprised you, or confirmed something you already suspected?

***A strong answer** names one real pattern from your tracker, like a category or a kind of small purchase, and says what it shows about your actual priorities.*

- What category took more than you expected?
- Where did small purchases add up?
- What does your spending tell you about your actual priorities right now, even if they're different from what you'd say out loud?

QUESTION 2

Your Financial Reality

Describe your current financial situation honestly, not for judgment but for clarity. You don't need to share specific numbers.

***A strong answer** describes your situation honestly without numbers, names your biggest pressure and one support, defines financial wellness in your own words, and connects money to your schoolwork and one other part of your wellness.*

- What does your financial life look like right now: tight, manageable, comfortable, complicated, somewhere in between?
- What's the biggest financial pressure you're dealing with this semester?
- What's one financial resource, habit, or support you already have that's helping, even a little?
- Which other part of your wellness (like emotional, physical, or social) does money affect most for you right now?
- In your own words, what does financial wellness mean to you, and how does money stress, or the lack of it, affect your schoolwork?

QUESTION 3

One Realistic Next Step

Based on what you noticed this week, what's one small, realistic thing you want to do differently, or keep doing, when it comes to money?

***A strong answer** names one specific step, connects it to something you noticed, and explains why it's realistic for your life right now.*

- It doesn't have to be dramatic. It just has to be honest and doable for your actual life right now.
- Why does this feel like the right next step for where you are?

QUESTION 4

Your Zero-Based Budget

Look at the zero-based budget you built in the Budget Builder. You don't need to share any dollar amounts.

***A strong answer** explains why you chose your categories, says whether your budget balances to zero (and what you'll adjust if it doesn't), and names one thing that building the budget showed you. No dollar amounts needed.*

- Which categories did you give jobs to, and why those?
- Did every dollar get a job, so your income minus your expenses and savings equals zero? If not, is money left over or short, and what will you adjust?
- What did giving every dollar a job show you that you hadn't noticed before?

QUESTION 5

Keeping It Private

If you used AI for any part of this module, what did you leave out of your prompts to protect your privacy? How did you describe your situation without sharing personal financial details? If you didn't use AI, that's a complete answer. Just say so.

***A strong answer** names what you kept out and how you worded things instead, or says plainly that you didn't use AI.*